

Digit takes a virtual leap into the near-future and paints a canvas of our likely digital lives to come: a city seen through a lens of augmented reality, gaze tracking, presence detection, human-powered devices, crowd-sourced energy, and sponsored dreams... Here's how the gadgets of tomorrow will be built for and into the human body...

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A sharp buzz. The dream faded. Leaving behind thin gossamers of memory and a strong desire to buy the latest fairness cream for men – assuredly the ladies would love it...

I suppressed the urge to place an order and cursed (yet again) the Odin Dream-Saver. The neural jack was great if you wanted a peaceful night's sleep but its propensity to insert sponsored advertisements was quite grating on the nerves, perhaps literally.

What was that buzz?

I pulled down my blanket and blinked thrice in quick succession to boot up my OdinVision, then took a weary peek at the wall. The wall's sensors locked in with the soft lenses of OdinVision, did a quick IR handshake, and threw up the most recent home notifications: due rent

(ignore), low on groceries (ignore), Star Wars XXIV: Revenge of Mickey download complete (a disappointment in waiting, judging by its prequel but I had to see it), and ah yes, the cause of the buzz – someone at the door. Rather, someone *was* at the door. Evidently tired of waiting, he placed something by the corridor, turned his back to the camera and left. Curious, I brought up the external camera feed on my OdinVision and trained the lens towards the package. The courier had left a box about a foot long and twice as deep. My heart fluttered, the OdinVision noting the elevated BPM. Could this be The Package? The Package was about the gadget, The Gadget. It was love at first sight for millions, circa CES 2049, a little more than a year ago. The star of the conference that year was a little pill. The pill was in essence a delivery mechanism for a series of nanobots. The marketing pitch went like this: take these pills and turn into a superhuman. A pill (which

came in both red and blue, naturally) and the contents therein would spread throughout your interior – tiny bots attaching themselves to specific chemical receptors inside your body. Much like a protein binds itself to a neural interface to give us the sensation of smell or touch, so would these nanobots find their neural mates and turn up the gain on the entire human condition by a few notches. Bots were thus designed to mate with sense organs, the major muscles, optic nerves, and organs to create an internal mesh that would let you see into the ultraviolet or infrared, hear well below 20Hz, taste much more than the paltry five basic tastes, and so on. The nanobots were meant to be taken in batches, over a period of weeks, to ensure complete internal coverage. They were designed to be powered by the body's own cells and would talk with each other and externally over the personal area network... or so said the marketing pitch...



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